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Careers Day Article: Army Career from Co-op student to Instructor

I joined the Army reserve when I was 18 years old and in my final year of high school. My plans were already cemented to pursue further education at Western University, and, at the time, I held a regular part-time at McDonald's. However, one day in the early fall two recruiters would appear at my school. They spoke about an opportunity where we could train and become soldiers while remaining as full-time students in high school. As a kid, I always wanted to be a soldier and many members of my family have served both in the Colombian and US militaries. I gave the co-op program a chance and it has been five years since that day.

During that time, I have had opportunities that as an adolescent I would have never imagined nor figured I would accomplish. I completed my Basic training and the first part of my infantry trade course, all within my 12th-grade year, and that same summer I graduated as a fully trained soldier. Throughout the years I have had tremendous and impactful experiences, such as conducting speaking engagements at elementary schools and high schools for Remembrance Day. I have also had the opportunity to work with the Canadian Rangers (3CRPG) and with the junior rangers, supporting their communities and advancing the cause of reconciliation. During the height of the Covid pandemic, and like many others, I supported my local community throughout those troubling times in the capacity of a soldier rather than as a civilian, all while completing my university undergrad. At length, these experiences prepared me for the challenges of service. Being away, being cold, tired, in pain, and sometimes even a little stressed, being part of a team was the most rewarding.

In more recent years, I have had the great privilege and greater responsibility of becoming a leader within the institution. Though many times an enormous challenge, I have had the advantage of being surrounded by experienced, professional, and dedicated mentors that have demonstrated what it means to be a good soldier and leader - proficient at their role and well-rounded as individuals. Because of these opportunities, I have been a Section commander within my unit for nearly two years and I have had the amazing experience of teaching on an Infantry PLQ and ISCC. These experiences and those mentioned previously were vital to my professional development but more critically, have allowed me to improve and develop a plethora of skills in communication, stress management, time management and so on. These skills have been tremendously advantageous within Academia and the civilian working world.

In closing, the Army Reserve for me has become a profession, a passion, and most importantly, a family. I am privileged and excited to inform the new generation of the great opportunity they now have. That teenager, that was mentioned earlier, has now become a leader, and part of something bigger than he could have ever imagined.